

moji

Add Values emoji reactions to thank you messages in the thanks slack channel or feel free to use them in GitLab.com, other slack channels and social media, when you see alignment to our values: GitLab's values.

Emoji	Custom values emoji	Meaning
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:handshake:	:collaboration-value:	Collaboration
:chartwithupwardstrend:	:results-value:	Results for Customers
:stopwatch:	:efficiency-value:	Efficiency
:globewithmeridians:	:diversity-value:	Diversity Inclusion and Belonging
:footprints:	:iteration-value:	Iteration
:eye:	:transparency-value:	Transparency

As a second iteration, we have added these custom emoji to GitLab to enable tanuki values reactions in issues, epics, and MRs within the gitlab-com and gitlab-org groups.

As a later iteration, we will begin tracking the number of emoji reactions for each value through the Reacji API and update this page with our findings!

Indicating availability

Indicate your availability by updating your own calendar using Google's "out of office" feature and include the dates you plan to be away in your automated response. Note that this feature will automatically decline any meeting invitations during the time frame you select.

1. Put your planned away time including holidays, vacation, travel time, and other leave in your own calendar. Please see Communicating your time off for more.
1. Set your working hours in your Google Calendar settings.
1. Utilize Time Off by Deel to keep other GitLab team members aware of your planned time away within Slack.

Informal communication

Informal communication is made up of interactions between co-workers that are unofficial in nature and focus on building social relationships outside of the normal hierarchy of a typical business structure.

In other words, it's what happens when we get to know each other and talk about anything other than work.

Informal communication is a vital part of GitLab culture, and we've listed 20+ ways to engage.

Not sure where to go?

If there is something that you want to discuss, but you do not feel that it is a reasonable option to discuss with either your manager or CEO, then you can reach out to any of the other C-level GitLab team members.

Start with a Merge Request

When possible, it's best practice to start a discussion with a Merge Request (MR) instead of an issue. An MR is associated with a specific change that is proposed and transparent for everyone to review and openly discuss. The nature of MRs facilitates discussions around a proposed solution to a problem that is actionable. An MR is actionable, while an issue will take longer to take action on.

1. Always open an MR for things you are suggesting and/or proposing. Whether something is not working right or we are iterating on a new internal process, it is worth opening a merge request with the minimal valuable change instead of opening an issue encouraging open feedback on the problem without proposing any specific change directly. Remember, an MR also invites discussion, but it's specific to the proposed change which facilitates focused decision.

1. Never ask someone to create an issue when they can default to the merge request.

1. Starting with a Merge Request is part of Handbook First and helps ensure the handbook is up-to-date when a decision is made. It is also how we make it possible for Everyone to Contribute. This is true, not just for updating the handbook but for updating all things.

1. Merge Requests, by default, are non-confidential. However, for things that are not public by default please open a confidential issue with suggestions to specific changes that you are proposing. The ability to create Confidential Merge Requests is also available. When possible, consider not including sensitive information so the wider community can contribute.

1. Not every solution will solve the problem at hand. Keep discussions focused by defining the problem first and explaining your rationale behind the Minimal Valuable Change (MVC) proposed in the MR.

1. Be proactive and consistent with communication on discussions that have external stakeholders such as customers. It's important to keep communication flowing to keep everyone up to date. MRs can appear stale if there aren't recent discussions and no clear definition on when another update will be provided, based on feedback. This leaves those subscribed in the dark, causing unnecessary surprise if something ends up delayed and suddenly jumps to the next milestone. It is important that MRs are closed in a timely manner through approving or rejecting the open requests.

1. Have a bias for action and do not aim for consensus. Every MR is a proposal, if an MRs author isn't responsive take ownership of it and complete it. Some improvement is better than none.

1. Cross link issues or other MRs with related conversations. E.g. if there's a Zendesk ticket that caused you to create a GitLab.com MR, make sure to document the MR link in the Zendesk ticket and vice versa. And when approving or rejecting the MR, include reason or response from Zendesk. Put the link at the top of each MR's description with a short mention of the relationship (Report, Dependency, etc.) and use one as the central one and ideally close the alternate if duplicate.

1. When providing links to specific lines of code relevant to the MR, always use a permalink (a link to a specific commit for the file). This ensures that the reference is still valid if the file changes. For more information, see [Link to specific lines of code](#).

1. If submitting a change for a feature, update the description with the final conclusions (Why an MR was rejected or why it was approved). This makes it much easier to see the current state of an issue for everyone involved in the implementation and prevents confusion and discussion

later on.

1. Submit the smallest viable and valuable thing. When proposing a change, submit the smallest reasonable commit, put suggestions for other enhancements in separate issues/MRs and link them. An MR can start off as only a problem description and TODO comments. If you're new to GitLab and are writing documentation or instructions, submit your first merge request for at most 20 lines.

1. Do not leave MRs open for a long time. MRs should be actionable -- stakeholders should have a clear understanding of what changed and what they are ultimately approving or rejecting.

1. Make a conscious effort to prioritize your work. The priority of items depends on multiple factors: Is someone waiting for the answer? What is the impact if you delay it? How many people does it affect, etc.? This is detailed in Engineering Work flow.

1. When submitting a MVC, ask for feedback from your peers. For example, if you're a designer and you propose a design, ping a fellow designer to review your work. If they suggest changes, you get the opportunity to improve your design and propose an alternative MR. This promotes collaboration and advances everyone's skills.

1. Respond to comments within a threaded discussion. If there isn't a discussion thread yet, you can use the Reply to comment button from the comments to create one. This will prevent comments from containing many interweaved discussions with responses that are hard to follow.

1. If your comment or answer contains separate topics, write separate comments for each, so others can address topics independently using the Reply to comment button.

1. If you have received any feedback or questions on your MR, try to acknowledge comments as that's how we ensure we create an environment of belonging for all team members. Merging your MR as-is without giving an answer or any response makes the commenters feel their opinions are unheard. If you are the Directly Responsible Individual (DRI) who does not have to make a fast decision, you can choose not to change your MR, but you should acknowledge the comments or feedback, consider if they warrant a change to your MR, and say why, not just what.

If there are many comments, you can choose to summarize key feedback areas and share your response at a high level. We appreciate that if you force a DRI to explain too much, you'll create incentives to ship projects under the radar. The fear of falling into a perpetual loop of explaining can derail a DRI, and cause people to defer rather than working with a bias for action. This is something we want to avoid.

When fast decisions are needed, we'll have to accept that people listened to us but don't owe us an explanation to have fast decisions based on everyone's input. The goals are to be transparent and collaborative--not to lose efficiency. Not everyone will agree, but we expect all people to disagree, commit, and disagree.

1. For GitLab, the product merge request guidelines are in the Contribution guide and code review guidelines for reviewers and maintainers are described in our Code Review Guidelines.

1. Even when something is not done, share it internally so people can comment early and prevent rework.

1. Create a **Draft** merge request to prevent an accidental early merge. Only use Draft when merging it would make things worse, which should rarely be the case when contributing to the handbook. Most merge requests that are in progress don't make things worse. In this case, do not use Draft; if someone merges it earlier than you expected just create a new merge request for additional items. Never ask someone to do a final review or merge something that still has Draft status. At that point you should be convinced it is good enough to go out.

1. If any follow-up actions are required on the issue after the merge request is merged (like reporting back to any customers or writing documentation), avoid auto-closing the issue.

1. If a project requires multiple approvals to accept your MR, feel free to assign multiple reviewers concurrently. This way the earliest available reviewer can start right away rather than being blocked by the preceding reviewer.

1. If the MR involved gets a lot of comments, you can turn it into a Manager Mention MR.

1. Consider recording a concise video or audio file outlining the merge request and uploading it to the GitLab Unfiltered channel on YouTube. This will make content more accessible, prevent future confusion, allow for multitasking (e.g. cooking dinner and listening to the video), and increase participation for folks who digest audio information better than visual.

Scaling Merge Requests through "Manager Mention MRs" (formerly Consolidated MRs)

Some merge requests that involve a big decision or change tend to collect a large amount of feedback. As GitLab grows in size, it is unrealistic for a single person to respond to potentially hundreds of comments. To remain efficient in these MRs and to make it scalable, it is important for the DRI to receive a clear signal of input that is shared on the merge request. Some MRs may be marked as "Manager Mention MRs" by clearly designating them as such at the beginning of the MR description with the following code block:

```
text
```

```
Manager Mention MR
```

This MR is a Manager Mention MR. Contributors should tag their manager when adding a comment. If managers are tagged they should either respond to the question or summarize and tag their manager.

Additionally, add the ~"Manager Mention MR" label to the merge request. This will make future analytics on Manager Mention merge requests more easily identifiable. It also enables managers to subscribe to the label to be notified when an MR has elected the Manager Mention MR designation.

We tried Manager Mention MR's for the first time in a recent announcement (2021-03-03) but this did not work well and we are working on making it better. We're starting with a more thoughtful and transparent process in our communications cadence and approach going forward, including all directs and people managers getting a few days' notice before important company-wide changes are announced to all team members. This will allow all directs and people managers to feel more enabled and better understand the why behind big changes in order to scale communication to team members.

For all managers: It is important to ground yourself in the contents of the changes before the announcement goes live to all team members. If a team member tags you in a Manager Mention MR, it is your role to respond candidly and thoughtfully to their question or comment. If the line of questioning in the Manager Mention MR gets out of your depth, ask the DRI to help answer. If a team member comments without a manager tagged, the comment will be closed with a link to this handbook section or closed without comment. In a situation where a team member leaves a wildly inappropriate comment in the Manager Mention MR, you should feel empowered to delete comment and talk to your team member 1:1. Consider subscribing to the label ~"Manager Mention MR" to be notified when MRs transition to this designation.

- What not to do: Not communicate to team members about company-wide changes. Ignoring team member questions, whether that's in a 1:1 or Manager Mention MR.

- What to do: If one of your team members has a suggestion, solution or sees an issue, see if talking through the communication will answer any of their questions. Team members are also

allowed to bring forward their ideas in the Manager Mention MR addressed to you, we want everyone to contribute. As a manager, you will be expected to communicate changes to your teams and also be present to answer any team member questions, whether that's in a 1:1 or Manager Mention MR. As a manager, it is part of your role to understand and own change management for your team and properly triage the process and expectations. Consider a synchronous call with the team member for further context, make a suggestion, link to additional context, delete any unnecessary comments from their team, or escalate to the author of the MR. Ensure that the comments of your reports you interact with were made after the Manager Mention label was added.

For team members: Check if the MR you are about to comment on has the ~"Manager Mention MR" label. Check each time as the label may have been added since you last commented. When leaving a comment in a Manager Mention MR, frame the comment as a question or suggestion to your manager directly, and not anyone else, including the DRI. We do this to scale communication, as it is unsustainable for the DRI to answer every question.

- What not to do: Leaving a comment and CC'ing your manager at the end of your post, but not addressing your manager directly.
- What to do: Address your manager directly at the beginning of your message as your comments should be addressed to your manager. If you have a suggestion, solution or see an issue with a big change, you can also bring it up directly to your manager. The MR is not a poll. Give suggestions on how to improve and try to find data that helps support your argument or change in the MR.

MRs should not start out as a Manager Mention MR as we prefer communication to be direct. They should only be designated as such after the number of comments on them grows to a level that is unsustainable for the DRI. An exception to this is compensation changes and other company-wide announcements that can be sensitive/contentious in nature since they have historically generated many comments.

When an MR is changed to be Manager Mention, the person making this change should add a comment stating this so that everyone tracking the MR can be informed.

Issues

Issues are valuable when there isn't a specific code change that is being proposed, such as:

- Crafting a research proposal to validate a problem or solution
- Ideating on designs in order to solve a particular problem
- Breaking down implementation tasks in order to deliver a solution iteratively
- Tracking progress of particular tasks, especially when an issue board is needed

When utilizing issues, it is still important to maintain focus by defining a single specific topic of discussion and the desired outcome that would result in the resolution of the issue. Issues should not be open-ended or go stale due to lack of resolution. For example, a team member may open an issue to track the progress of a blog post with associated to-do items that need to be completed by a certain date (e.g. first draft, peer review, publish). Once the specific items are completed, the issue can successfully be closed.

Below are a few things to remember when creating issues:

1. When closing an issue leave a comment explaining why you are closing the issue and what the MVC outcome was of the discussion (if it was implemented or not).

1. We keep our promises and do not make external promises without internal agreement.

1. Be proactive and consistent with communication on discussions that have external stakeholders such as customers. It's important to keep communication flowing to keep everyone up to date. Issues can appear stale if there aren't recent discussions and no clear definition on when another update will be provided, based on feedback. This leaves those subscribed in the dark, causing unnecessary surprise if something ends up delayed and suddenly jumps to the next milestone. It is important that issues are closed in a timely manner. One way of doing this is having the current assignee set a due date for when they will provide another update. This can be days or weeks ahead depending on the situation, prioritization, and available capacity that we may have.

Pro Tip: When creating a Merge Request you can add closes: insert issue number here] and when the Merge Request is merged, the issue will automatically close. You can see an example of this [here. Note: Automatic issue closing is disabled on some projects.

1. If a user suggests an enhancement, try and find an existing issue that addresses their concern, or create a new one. Ask if they'd like to elaborate on their idea in an issue to help define the first MVC via a subsequent MR.

1. Cross link issues or MRs with related conversations. Another example is to add "Report: " lines to the issue description with links to relevant issues and feature requests. When done, add a comment to relevant issues (and close them if you are responsible for reporting back, or reassign if you are not). This prevents internal confusion and us failing to report back to the reporters.

1. When cross-linking issues or MRs, include a preview of the content you are linking, to facilitate low-context communication:

1. Good: this would cause performance issue similar to 123456. The reader has full information on first read and can refer to the link for more.

1. Avoid: this would cause issue similar to 123456. The reader needs to click the link and find the relevant information among other discussion threads, before switching back to the original discussion.

1. When providing links to specific lines of code relevant to the issue, always use a permalink (a link to a specific commit for the file). This ensures that the reference is still valid if the file changes. For more information, see Link to specific lines of code.

1. Prioritize your work on issues in the current milestone.

1. Use the public issue trackers on GitLab.com for everything since we work out in the open. Issue trackers that can be found on the relevant page in the handbook and in the projects under the gitlab-com group.

1. Assign an issue to yourself as soon as you start to work on it, but not before that time. If you complete part of an issue and need someone else to take the next step, re-assign the issue to that person.

1. Ensure the issue title states what the desired outcome should be. For instance, for bugs make sure the issue states the desired result, not the current behavior.

1. Regularly update the issue description with the latest information and its current status, especially when important decisions were made during the discussion. The issue description should be the single source of truth.

1. If you want someone to review an issue, do not assign them to it. Instead, @-mention them in an issue comment. Being assigned to an issue is a signal that the assignee should or intends to work on it. So you should not assign someone to an issue and misrepresent this with a false

signal.

1. If you'd like to inform someone about an issue or assign a task to them, do so via an issue comment, not only by adding them to the description. The to-do item generated when you mention someone in an issue description provides little context for the action you're requesting. But using a comment to explicitly inform someone of the action you'd like them to take ensures that when they read the associated to-do item they won't need to read the entire issue to gather the context they need to complete the work.

1. Do not close an issue until it is done. It's okay to explicitly ask if everyone is on board and in agreement on how to move forward, whether to iterate, close the open issue, or create a subsequent MR to implement a MVC.

1. Once a feature is done, update the description to add a link to the corresponding documentation. When using a Search Engine, issues often appear before documentation pages, which makes it harder to find the relevant information about the feature.

1. Write issues so that they exclude private information. This way, the issue can be public. Only use confidential issues, if the issue must contain non-public information. Note: Confidential issues are accessible to all members of the project with Reporter access and above. You may consider using a Google Doc for items that require a stricter level of confidentiality.

1. If the content within a public issue transitions to become what is deemed confidential non-public information, the issue may be made confidential.

1. If the content of a public issue draws comments that are deemed in violation of our code of conduct the issue may be locked and may undergo moderation.

How to make a company wide announcement

1. Consider the subject and the audience.

Questions you might want to ask yourself: Is this relevant to all team members globally?

Is this something important, urgent and high priority? Is there a better place for this communication, such as a more informal Slack channel?

1. Keep it simple, brief and summarize what is important. Cover the 5 W's. What, Why, Who, When, Where (you can also add How, if required as a call to action). The majority of information should still be in the Handbook which you include links to.

1. Common company wide announcements include (but are not limited to): organization changes, policy iterations, requests to participate in a company survey, unveiling the next GitLab Contribute location, codebase migrations, process improvement and security/safety announcements.

1. Remember Handbook First.

When you announce anything, include links to the respective Handbook pages for more information. Consider adding link to an Issue if the information is not public yet.

1. Optional AMA.

If desired and appropriate, offer a company wide Zoom call to host an AMA (Ask Me Anything). Oftentimes, questions can be managed within the Discussion tab of a GitLab Issue or Merge Request. For broad announcements, such as registration opening for GitLab Contribute, an AMA may be better suited for a large volume of inquiries. To schedule a company wide call, please make a request in the people-connect Slack channel, and include a Google Doc in the invite for questions.

1. Remember we are a global company with significant time-zone differences. Unless there is a reason to do otherwise, ensure any time-sensitive calls to action or announcements are made when the whole company has enough time to action. Consider different timezones, non-linear work days, and PTO. Announcements should be made ideally 72 hours (at minimum 24 hours) in advance

of a due date. This is to prevent APAC/EMEA team members missing important announcements posted outside their normal working hours.

Sometimes a late announcement is better than none at all, and acknowledging those who will miss it might be a kind gesture, such as "Apologies to our APAC/EMEA friends for the late notice".

Posting in company-fyi

Our company-wide announcements channel is company-fyi.

It is an announcement only channel, meaning that communications need to be approved before they can be posted. To minimize noise, announcements made in company-fyi should not be duplicated in whats-happening-at-gitlab. Be mindful of the attention economy.

In order to post or have a message posted in company-fyi, please reach out to the internal communications team or your function's executive who can approve the message and post it.

Examples of what should not go in company-fyi (as per new group guidelines):

- Competition prize winner announcements
- Org change or new team member announcements (unless they are E-group)
- Promotion of an optional non-company-wide internal event
- Announcement that directly impacts less than 75% of team members
- Actions required from team members is not critical or timely

The above should all go in the new whats-happening-at-GitLab channel (formerly the company-announcement channel).

mermaid

graph TB

```
everybody{{"Do you want to reach the entire company?"}}
```

```
important{{"How important is it?"}}
```

```
permission{{"Do you have permission<br>
```

```
to post in company-fyi?"}}
```

```
urgent{{"Is it urgent?"}}
```

```
reconsider{{"Are you sure you can't reach the people you need by posting in topic  
channels?"}}
```

```
channel-important>"Post in company-fyi"]
```

```
channel-important-ask>"Ask your function's executive<br>  
to post in company-fyi"]
```

```
channel-general>"Post in whats-happening-at-gitlab"]
```

```
channel-topic>"Post in the most topical channel"]
```

```
repost(["Repost in the 1-2 most appropriate channel(s) based on your topic/audience"])
```

```
no-repost(["Do not repost"])
```

```
classDef question fill: ECECFF
```

```
class everybody,important,permission,urgent,reconsider question;
```

```
classDef action fill: a2f2a9
```

```
class channel-important,channel-important-ask,channel-general,channel-topic,repost,no-repost
```


action;

classDef repost fill: f2d3a2
class repost,no-repost repost;

everybody -- Yes --> important
everybody -- No --> channel-topic

important -- need-to-know --> permission
important -- good-to-know --> reconsider

permission -- Yes --> channel-important
permission -- No --> urgent

reconsider -- Yes --> channel-general
reconsider -- No --> channel-topic

urgent -- No --> channel-important-ask
urgent -- Yes --> channel-general

channel-topic --> repost
channel-general --> repost
channel-important --> no-repost
channel-important-ask --> no-repost

Posting in whats-happening-at-gitlab

Due to the volume of posts in the Slack channel, we recommend that you do not use whats-happening-at-gitlab as a sole location for important announcements as information might get lost or muted. Examples of important items include but are not limited to:

- Anything involving GitLab team member policy, such as changes in benefits, laws, review cycles, etc.
- Urgent matters that can't wait for company-fyi but still need to be communicated to everyone such as service outages or last minute event changes

Meetings

Common meeting problems

Meetings are incredibly expensive since they require synchronous time.

The most common meeting problems can all be addressed by following the above guidelines around scheduling meetings.

Some of the most common meetings problems are outlined below:

Problem	Solution
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Present instead of Q&A	Pre-record presentations on YouTube, so meetings are only Q&A
Meetings set up for or default to brainstorming	People should default to making thoughtful proposals async and building upon them in meetings, if needed
No agenda with edit rights for everyone	Ensure that every meeting has an agenda and is available for everyone to edit
People are late to meetings or don't have time to use the restroom between meetings	Use Speedy Meetings to give people breathing space before their next meeting

Everyone is responsible for notes

If folks are involved in a meeting and have capacity to do so, they should take notes using GitLab's Live Doc Meetings principles. This is important, because:

1. Meetings at GitLab should have notes (for a single source of truth and to enable async participation among other reasons)

1. In the absence of this joint commitment to note-taking, this is the type of work that is likely to fall disproportionately to underrepresented groups. This is not in line with our diversity, inclusion, and belonging value.

It may look like a few people are already taking notes, do not see this as a deterrent for helping. Initial note takers may be first to show up and then see it as their responsibility to continue if no one else is stepping in.

While meetings recordings are helpful, written notes are more efficient to read and offer greater opportunities for async engagement. Takes notes even when a meeting is being recorded.

Engaging EBAs in note-taking

GitLab Executive Business Administrators sometimes support teams by taking notes. Since note taking takes time away from their other activities and can often be done by other folks, consider the following before engaging an EBA in a meeting solely for note taking purposes.

1. Can the folks already in this meeting cover note taking responsibilities, or is there a reason to engage an EBA in this capacity?

1. Can other folks be identified ahead of time or at the start of the meeting to ensure adequate coverage?

1. How does this stack against the EBAs other priorities? You can check directly with the EBA or their manager.

Smart note taking in meetings

Note taking helps us to work asynchronously. Team members can add thoughts to an agenda in advance of a meeting and understand what was discussed if they cannot attend. It also offers a record of discussion.

Consider the following best practice when taking notes in meetings:

1. If at the start of the meeting, it does not look like all team members will contribute to note-taking, identify a set of note-takers who will be responsible for this activity within the meeting

1. Note-taking can be a lot for a single person to stay on top of--especially when there is a fast moving conversation with many speakers. Team members should still feel empowered to contribute by helping with notes as needed, even if there is someone assigned.

- Another good reference is the CEO Shadow handbook page tips section, specifically It's helpful if shadow one takes notes as the first speaker is talking, then shadow two starts when the next speaker continues the conversation. Shadow one can pick up note taking again when the next speaker contributes. By alternating this way, the shadows are better able to keep up with all the participants in the conversation. This advice can be used in general meetings as well.

1. Ask others to scribe answers in real-time to allow the person who asked the question to focus on the answer. Touch up the answer when the conversation has moved on to something less relevant.

1. It can be hard to keep up with the dialog and capture quality notes when there's fast back and forth conversation. Lead by example and write when you're not talking, expect others will write when you're talking.

1. Focus on noting speakers and their key points over capturing all words said. Extensive note-taking should not happen at the expense of correct note-taking.

1. Write down your questions in the agenda before vocalizing. Always ask people to vocalize their questions to provide the most detailed context and for audio-only playbacks.

1. Use discretion in taking notes if sensitive topics are being discussed. For example, do not take notes on not-public information if the agenda may be available to an audience who should not be privy to this information.

1. If someone requests folks to stop taking notes, stop for the duration of the discussion unless there is verbal confirmation that note-taking should resume. Ask for the confirmation before typing before you resume note-taking.

1. At the end of the meeting, clearly capture key takeaways, next steps, and DRIs.

If you have any questions about what may or may not be a sensitive topic, please refer to our SAFE Framework or reach out via the safe Slack channel

Few meetings with presentations

Presenting during meetings requires valuable synchronous time. Instead, recorded presentations make content accessible, prevent confusion, and increase participation for team members that prefer consuming content asynchronously. Remember it is not required to have a presentation or have a pre-recorded presentation.

In the video below, GitLab co-founder, Sid Sijbrandij, explains why there are no presentations in most meetings.

{{< youtube "32GJ2ehUBhs" >}}

Pre-recorded presentations enable:

- Allows time for Q&A, which enables attendees to have their questions answered without running out of time.
- Reinforces GitLab's Bias Towards Asynchronous Communication because it allows a distributed team to consume the presentation asynchronously.
- Strengthens self-service and self-learning by maximizing the meeting time's efficiency to ensure that team members have their voices heard during the Q&A.
- Standardizes the approach to meetings across the organization.

- Includes transcripts that can boost content value, help team members focus, and increase accessibility.
- Flexibility in viewing using rewind and playback speed adjustments.
- Encourages and enables greater participation from neurodiverse team members who might take added time to process and reflect before asking questions.
- Allows for selective watching of presentation material for a certain period.

There are times when presenting during a meeting is needed. This may occur when adding more context to a specific topic on slides. If this is the case, consider the following:

- A presentation, with optional attendance and mandatory recording. This will allow clarifying questions to be asked and answered efficiently and enables team members to watch async.
- Include an async Q&A doc for team members who did not attend the presentation.
- Ensure the async Q&A doc is linked in the YouTube description.

Best Practices for Pre-Recorded Presentations

1. Use Zoom to create a pre-recorded video presentation.
1. Post the recording to the GitLab Unfiltered YouTube channel and attach it to the meeting agenda.
1. At least 24 hours in advance of the meeting, announce in Slack Channels that the meeting has a pre-recorded video, and all attendees are advised to watch beforehand.

Framework for meetings with presentations

While most meetings should not have presentations, there are a few exceptions. Specifically, we may use synchronous touch points in meetings with large numbers of folks. These tend to be meetings used for building team cohesion and alignment. For example, GitLab Assembly or the Functional Leaders Meeting.

GitLab has the following meeting framework for determining which meetings should have presentations:

Presentation Approach	Types of meetings with few participants	Types of meetings with many participants
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No presentations (async prep)	Most meetings	AMA
Presentations	These meetings should not happen	Assembly and other large team meetings

Meeting introduction guidelines

Introductions can be helpful during some external meetings, such as executive sales calls. In those meetings, use these guidelines:

1. Agree ahead of time to do introductions so everyone is prepared for it.
 1. Create a list of people with their roles in a shared agenda and use that for the introduction sequence.
 1. Each person should introduce themselves so that everyone can see that person on Zoom.
 1. The person introducing themselves hands it over to the next person in the agenda.
- Make sure you're never screen sharing when people are introducing themselves.

Scheduling meetings

1. Every scheduled meeting should either have a Google Presentation (for example for functional updates that don't require participation) or a Google Doc (for most meetings) linked. If it is a Google Doc it should have an agenda, including any preparation materials (can be a presentation). For a step-by-step guide on GitLab meeting best practices, visit our [Live Doc Meetings](#) page.

- No agenda is required for coffee chats. Note that only meetings that are primarily social in nature should be labeled as a coffee chat in the calendar invite.

- A suggested format for 1:1 agendas can be found on the [1:1 leadership](#) page.

1. For team members working in AMER timezones who regularly collaborate with EMEA team members:

- If all meeting attendees are located in AMER timezones, the meeting should be scheduled outside of the PST morning block.

- The PST morning block should be reserved for cross-regional collaboration with team members whose timezones make it harder for them to meet later in the day.

1. For team members working in AMER timezones who regularly collaborate with APAC team members:

- If all meeting attendees are located in AMER timezones, the meeting should be scheduled outside of the PST afternoon block.

- The PST afternoon block should be reserved for cross-regional collaboration with team members whose timezones make it harder for them to meet earlier in the day.

- Due to the number of timezones covered in APAC, the PST afternoon block will only overlap with the Eastern most APAC countries

1. If you want to ask GitLab team members if they are available for an event please send a calendar invite with Google Calendar using your Google GitLab account to their Google GitLab account. When you add a GitLab team member as a "Guest" in Google Calendar, you can click the See Guest Availability button to check availability and find a time on their calendar. These calendar invites will automatically show up on all parties calendars even when the email is not opened. It is an easier way to ensure everyone has visibility to the meeting and member's status. Please respond quickly to invites so people can make necessary plans.

1. If you want to check if a team member is available for an outside meeting, create a calendar appointment and invite the team member only after they respond yes. Then invite outside people.

1. When scheduling a call with multiple people, invite them using a Google Calendar that is your own, or one specific to the people joining, so the calendar item doesn't unnecessarily appear on other people's calendars.

1. If you want to move a meeting just move the calendar appointment instead of reaching out via other channels. Note the change at the top of the description.

1. Please click 'Guests can modify event' so people can update the time in the calendar instead of having to reach out via other channels. You can configure this to be checked by default under Event Settings.)

1. When scheduling a meeting we value people's time and prefer the "speedy meetings" setting in our Google Calendar. This gives us meetings of, for example, 25 or 50 minutes leaving some time to:

- Write notes and reflect
- Respond to urgent messages
- Take a bio break
- Stretch your legs
- Grab a snack

1. When scheduling a meeting, please try to have it start at :00 (hour) or :30 (mid-hour) to leave common start times available for other meetings on your attendees' calendars. Meetings should be for the time needed, so if you need 15 minutes just book that.

1. When creating a calendar event that will be used company wide, please place it on the GitLab Team Meetings Calendar. That way the event is easily located by all individuals.
1. When you need to cancel a meeting, make sure to delete/decline the meeting and choose the option Delete & update guests to make sure everyone knows you can't attend and don't wait for you.
1. If you want to schedule a meeting with a person not on the team please use Calendly. Use Google Calendar directly if scheduling with a GitLab team member.
1. Materials Review are scheduled as all day not busy events as a reminder three days before the scheduled call.
1. When scheduling recurring meetings, consider using (UTC+00:00) Coordinated Universal Time as the meeting time zone,
so that the meeting time does not change for others when your local time zone changes.

Cross-regional Working Hours Recommendations

If you're scheduling a meeting across multiple regions, consider using the time ranges below to respect common working hours.

The suggested times are organized by the regions that you're trying to accommodate.

Each suggested window is shown in the local time zone.

For example, if your meeting includes team members in EMEA and AMER, you could consider scheduling from 8:00 AM to 10:00 AM Pacific Time.

Note: Time zone offsets change throughout the year due to Daylight Savings Time, Summer Time, and similar time changes, so these suggested times may be less convenient at different times of year.

EMEA/AMER

Timezone	Start	End
London/Lisbon	04:00 PM	06:00 PM
Paris/Rome	05:00 PM	07:00 PM
Istanbul/Tel Aviv	06:00 PM	08:00 PM
Abu Dhabi	07:00 PM	09:00 PM
Mumbai	08:30 PM	09:30 PM
Pacific Time	08:00 AM	10:00 AM
Eastern Time	11:00 AM	01:00 PM

APAC/AMER

Timezone	Start	End
Sydney	09:00 AM	11:00 AM
Tokyo	08:00 AM	10:00 AM
Hong Kong	07:00 AM	09:00 AM
Ho Chi Minh	07:00 AM	08:00 AM
Pacific Time	04:00 PM	06:00 PM
Eastern Time	07:00 PM	09:00 PM

EMEA/APAC

Timezone	Start	End
----- ----- -----		
Lisbon/Dublin	08:00 AM	10:00 AM
Paris/Rome	09:00 AM	11:00 AM
Istanbul/Tel Aviv	10:00 AM	12:00 PM
Mumbai	12:30 PM	02:30 PM
Ho Chi Minh	02:00 PM	04:00 PM
Hong Kong	03:00 PM	05:00 PM
Sydney	05:00 PM	07:00 PM

Multi-session meeting naming

When scheduling meetings with two or more sessions (usually when trying ensure worldwide coverage for all team members), name them after the topic, appended with a session number based on the order they show up in the calendar.

Team members will see the meeting invites in their email or calendar in relation to their local time zone and can decide for themselves which session to attend, based on their working hours.

Avoid:

- Terms like friendly or early / late, as these terms are overly subjective.

An early meeting for one team member might seem late for someone in a different time zone.

Or a west coast AMER meeting might seem "APAC friendly", but not to someone in western APAC who is still asleep when the meeting starts.

- Using AMER, EMEA, APAC, or only unless the meeting is specifically targeting members of that time zone.

These terms give the impression that only team members from those timezones are welcome, when people from any timezone with any working style are welcome.

For example:

Scheduled time	Preferred	Avoid
----- ----- -----		
07:00:00 UTC	"All members meeting - Session 1"	"All members meeting - EMEA/AMER"
15:00:00 UTC	"All members meeting - Session 2"	"All members meeting - AMER/APAC friendly"
23:00:00 UTC	"All members meeting - Session 3"	"All members meeting - APAC/EMEA only"

Video calls

1. Use video calls if you find yourself going back and forth in an issue/via email or over chat. Guideline: if you have gone back and forth 3 times, it's time for a video call.

1. Sometimes it's better to not have a video call. Consider these tradeoffs:

- It is difficult (or impossible) to multi-task in a video call.

- It may be more efficient to have an async conversation in an issue, depending on the topic.

- A video call is limited in time: A conversation in an issue can start or stop at any time, whenever there's interest. It is async.

- A video call is limited in people: You can invite anybody into an async conversation at any time in an issue. You don't have to know who the relevant parties are ahead of time. Everyone can contribute at any time. A video call is limited to invited attendees (and those who have accepted).

- You can easily "promote" an async conversation from an issue to a video call, as needed. The reverse is harder. So there is lower risk to start with an async conversation.

- For a newcomer to the conversation, it's easier and more efficient to parse an issue, than read a video transcript or watch it.

- Conversations in issues are easily searchable. Video calls are not.

1. Try to have your video on at all times because it's much more engaging for participants.

- Do not worry if you can't pay attention at the meeting because you're doing something else, you are the manager of your attention. The flip-side of being the manager of your own attention is that others should not hesitate to request your attention when it is needed.

- During internal calls, it's okay to eat on video if you're hungry or the call is during your lunch time (please turn your mic off). To maintain professionalism, if you are presenting or facilitating a customer call please try to avoid eating. If eating during a customer call is unavoidable, please turn off your video and mute your mic.

- You should ensure that you are properly dressed for all video calls. Properly dressed means that you are wearing clothing that covers the top and bottom parts of your body. We do not have a strict dress code policy, but want to make sure that all participants on video calls feel comfortable. If you cannot be properly dressed for the entirety of the call, you should not join, but watch the recording at a later time.

- Having pets, children, significant others, friends, and family visible during video chats is encouraged. If they are human, ask them to wave at your remote team member to say "Hi in your native language".

- Do not feel forced to have your video on, use your best judgement.

1. Additional points for video calls with customers or partners:

- Results come first. Your appearance, location and background is less important than making customers successful so don't wait for the perfect time / place when you can engage a customer right away.

- Communicating that GitLab is an enterprise grade product and service provider is supported by the way you present yourself. Most of the time, if you would not wear something or present yourself in a certain way at a customer's office, candidate interview, or partner meeting in person then it's probably not the right choice on a video call with them either.

- Green screens are a great background solution. It's great to work in your garage or basement! Just get a green screen behind you and put up a professional background image to present well externally and still use the rest of the room how you want!

1. We prefer Zoom.

1. Google Calendar also has a Zoom plugin where you can easily add a Zoom link for a video call to the invite.

1. For meetings that are scheduled with Zoom:

- After reviewing our Zoom handbook page, if you have additional questions, please contact IT in the ithelp Slack channel.

- Note that if you select to record meetings to the cloud (setting within Zoom), you must include the text REC] in the meeting title if you want them to be automatically placed in the GitLab Videos Recorded folder in Google Drive on an hourly basis via a [scheduled pipeline.

- You can find these videos in Google Drive by looking under Shared drives and GitLab Videos Recorded. If you do not have access to this drive, contact IT Ops.

- The script for syncing the files is here.
- Note also that after a meeting ends, Zoom may take some time to process the recording before it is actually available. The sync to Google Drive happens on the hour mark, so if the recording is not available, it may take another hour to be transferred.
- 1. Consider using a utility to easily mute/unmute yourself, see Shush in the tools section.
- 1. Hybrid calls are annoying.
- 1. Always be sure to advise participants to mute their mics if there is unnecessary background noise to ensure the speaker is able to be heard by all attendees.
- 1. We start on time and do not wait for people. People are expected to join no later than the scheduled minute of the meeting (before :01 if it is scheduled for :00). The question 'is everyone here' is not needed.
- 1. It feels rude in video calls to interrupt people.

This is a situation where we have to do something counter intuitive to make all-remote meetings work.

In GitLab, everyone is encouraged to interrupt the speaker in a video call to ask a question or offer context.

We want everyone to contribute instead of a monologue.

Interrupting can be done by clicking "Raise Hand" in Zoom, by physically raising your hand on video, or by interrupting verbally.

As a speaker, allow yourself to be interrupted.

As a listener, advocate (verbally if necessary) for those who have raised their hand.

Just like in-person meetings be cognizant of when, who, and how you interrupt, we don't want maninterrupting.

- 1. We end on the scheduled time. It might feel rude to end a meeting, but you're actually allowing all attendees to be on time for their next meeting.
- 1. Do not use the chat of products like Zoom to communicate during the call, use the linked document instead. Zoom Chat has been configured for a 30 day retention. This allows everyone to contribute additional questions, answers, and links in the relevant place. It also makes it easier for people in conflicting timezones to contribute questions before the call and makes it easier to review questions and answers after the call, which can be before watching the recording.
- 1. You do not need to remind other people to vocalize their questions. Just say their name and a keyword of the question, e.g. 'Jay about credit-cards'.
- 1. Every comment is document worthy, even small support comments such as +1 or Very Cool!.
- 1. We encourage the recording and sharing of everything to our YouTube Unfiltered channel.
- 1. It is unusual to smoke in an open office or video conference, vaping is associated with this. For this reason we ask that you don't vape during calls, and if you absolutely have to, kindly switch your camera off.
- 1. Speak up when you notice something is not working. If you notice someone's microphone, web cam or latency is causing issues for them it is good to speak up. On a video call it can be harder for the speaker to notice that they aren't being understood compared to a face to face conversation. As such you will be doing them a favour by speaking up early to let them know that they are having a problem. Also see Hear nothing say something for further explanation.

You are the manager of your attention

You are the manager of your attention, and you decide when you do or don't pay attention in a meeting.

You will always have more work than time in your life.

If you get invited to a meeting you don't think you should go to, you should decline the meeting.

It is better to cancel than to show up and not pay attention.

On the other hand, not every part of a meeting is relevant, but it can sometimes be helpful to have more people in a call.

If you only have one discussion point, if possible, try to reorder the meeting agenda to have your point first and then drop from the call.

If you get asked a question when you're not paying attention, it is an okay use of time to repeat a question every now and then.

If training is required for one's role, team members should plan to give the training full attention--especially if engagement in discussions or breakout rooms is required. If training is 'nice to learn' or 'optional' for team members, multi-tasking can be done at the team members discretion.

We don't use the first 15 minutes of a meeting to read the materials like they do at Amazon.

You can use the start of a meeting to review the materials for the meeting if you need to, given you do not have to be paying attention, but that should not delay the start of the meeting for the people that already have questions based on the materials. Meetings start on time at GitLab.

Do not use your camera to signal you're not paying attention; cameras should always be on.

Do not ask meeting attendees to pay attention

There are too few hours in a week, so we expect each team member to manage their attention. If you're hosting a meeting, don't tell people to give you their attention or stop multi-tasking. Respect each team member's agency over their time. Instead of demanding attention, earn participants' attention by organizing and facilitating meetings so they are compelling to attendees.

First post is a badge of honor

You should take pride in being the first person to add a question to a meeting agenda, however unlike the First post meme we do want the first post to be more than just "First!". The meeting DRI will be happy to see there is a question ready before to kick off the meeting. The Meeting DRI should remember to thank the person for asking the first question.

Do not do a countdown before ending a call

Never do a countdown or say something like. "I'll give it x seconds", people are very unlikely to ask a question if you do that. Either ask for a question, wait for a question, or end the call.

Hybrid calls are annoying

In calls that have remote participants everyone should use their own equipment (camera,

headset, screen).

When multiple people share equipment the following problems arise for remote participants:

- Can't hear the sharing people well
- Background noise since the microphone of the sharing people is on all the time
- Can't clearly see facial expressions since each face takes up only a small part of the screen
- Can't easily see who is talking since the screen shows multiple people
- Hard getting a word in since their delay is longer than for the sharing people

The people sharing equipment also have problems because they don't have their own equipment:

- Can't easily screen share something themselves
- Trouble seeing details in screen sharing since the screen is further away from them
- Can't scroll through a slide deck at their own pace
- Sharing people can't easily participate (view or type) in a shared document with the agenda and meeting notes.

The disadvantages for remote people are much greater than for the sharing people and hard to notice for the sharing people.

The disadvantages cause previously remote participants to travel to the meeting to be in person for a better experience.

The extra travel is inefficient since it is time consuming, expensive, bad for the environment, and unhealthy.

Theoretically you can have multiple people in a room with their own equipment but in practice it is much better to be in separate rooms:

- It is annoying to first hear someone talk in the room and then hear it over audio with a delay.
- It is hard to consistently mute yourself when not talking to prevent someone else's voice coming through your microphone as well.

Types of meetings

Ask Me Anything meetings

Ask Me Anything meetings can be a useful opportunity for team members to meet a new leader, learn more about an existing team member, or gain clarity on a recent change.

1. Format: AMAs use the whole meeting time for questions from attendees, answered by the host.

Fireside Chats

Fireside chats are informal conversations between a host and a guest. The guest is typically a new leader, board member, or guest speaker. They are a useful opportunity to learn specific information about these individuals and their professional careers and personal interests.

Fireside chats allow the audience to learn more about the guests in a casual and approachable setting.

Format: In advance of the call, the host will prepare questions and share them with the guest. During the call, the host will moderate the conversation with the guest, by verbalizing the prepared questions. There is specific amount of time reserved at the end of the agenda for questions from attendees.

Walk and Talk calls

A Walk and Talk call is when team members step away from their computers and get outside for a meeting. The difference between a coffee chat and a Walk and Talk call is that a Walk and Talk call can be held with people that you interact with frequently at GitLab. It could be social in nature or focused on a specific problem/topic that needs to be discussed. If it's a problem-solving focused discussion, the outcome should be captured in a merge request. It should not be used if the problem being discussed requires screen sharing or detailed note taking. There are great physical and mental health benefits to a walk and talk call. There are also benefits with increased focus and creativity. A Walk and Talk can also help prevent Zoom fatigue.

The team members can use Zoom on their mobile device with the audio only function, or call one another from their preferred mobile device. A walk and talk call should be agreed to in advance to ensure that the local weather is compatible for a walk in both locations and that the walk and talk call fits into both team members' schedules. We've created a Slack channel walk-and-talk-meetings where, if you'd like, you can share pictures from your walking meetings.

Release retrospectives and kickoffs {kickoffs}

After GitLab releases a new version every month, we have a 30-minute call a few days later reflecting on what could have been better:

1. What went well this month?
1. What went wrong this month?
1. What could we have done better?

We spend the first part of the retrospective meeting reviewing the action items from the previous month.

On the 8th of each month (or the next business day), we have a kickoff meeting for the version that will be released in the following month. The product team and other leads will have already had discussions on what should be prioritized for that release. The purpose of this kickoff is to get everyone on the same page and to invite comments.

Both the retrospectives and kickoffs are live streamed to our GitLab Unfiltered YouTube channel and posted to our Unfiltered YouTube channel.

Deep Dives

As GitLab continues to grow, sharing knowledge across the community becomes even more important.

The Deep Dives page describes initiatives we are trying to encourage. This aligns with how we work since everything at GitLab is public by default.

Daily Sync Escalation Process

GitLab has a specific process to follow in crisis situations to ensure effective communications. Details can be found in the internal handbook.

Presentations

1. All presentations are made in Google Slides using our templates.
1. Please allow anyone at GitLab to edit the presentation (preferred) or at least comment on the presentation.
1. If the content can be public use File > Publish to the web > Publish to get a URL and paste that in the speaker notes of the first slide (commonly the title slide).
1. The title of every slide should be the message you want the audience to take away, not the subject matter. So use 'Our revenue more than doubled' instead of 'Revenue growth'.
1. Slide titles should not be more than one line. Be concise in highlighting the key point that you want to make.
1. Do not add a period at the end of a title.
1. During introductions, make sure that nobody is presenting. We remember people better and have more empathy when we clearly see peoples faces and expressions.
1. At the end of the presentation, when you go to Q&A, stop presenting in Zoom. This way the other people can see the person who is speaking much better.
1. All presentations at GitLab should be based on screenshots of the handbook, issues, merge requests, review apps, and data from GitLab Insights and Sisense charts. In most cases it shouldn't be needed to make content uniquely for the presentation. If you need something that doesn't exist yet add it to the place it belongs and then copy it into the presentation. This way we can have a Single Source of Truth for everything we do. By using screenshots you indicate to people you did the right thing and they can find the canonical source in the appropriate place. Having to find information by digging through old presentations doesn't scale. Consider linking the screenshot to the original source.
1. Do not use cumulative graphs internally. For example total ARR, total user, total contributors, or total Merge Requests. Instead use IACV per dollar spend, users added per month, contributions per month, or MR rate. Cumulative graphs can hide trends and are far more likely to be misinterpreted. The only acceptable use of cumulative graphs is for external presentations where they are expected by the audience and commonly used.
1. When your presentation includes graphs or other data, make sure your graphs have clear titles and dimensions. Make sure your data has significant figures and labels. For example, use 'January: 1.95M projects' instead of 'January: 1.95M'. Keep in mind that your audience may not have the full context, especially if they are reading the presentation asynchronously.
1. When giving a presentation, your commentary should not be a regurgitation of the words in the slide. The audience can read the slide for themselves; your commentary should focus on the most important takeaways.

Video and presentation tips with Lorraine Lee

On 2022-01-20, the L&D team hosted Lorraine Lee for a live speaker series on video and presentation techniques in an all-remote workspace.

Key points addressed in the training include:

- Increase your confidence on video using lighting, visuals, and curating your environment

- Keep your audience engaged with movement, power words, and the think/do/feel matrix
- Stay connected with your audience by smiling, making eye contact, and framing yourself in video
- Insert energy by standing up, projecting, and using hand gestures

Watch the replay below:

{{< youtube "A5KtmrgVqr8" >}}

Writing style guidelines

As you're creating external or business content for GitLab, please refer to the GitLab Content Style Guide. For technical content, you can reference this word list.

This list offers additional guidance for written communication at GitLab:

1. Do not use rich text, it makes it hard to copy/paste. Use Markdown to format text that is stored in a Git repository. In Google Docs, use "Normal text" using the style/heading/formatting dropdown and paste without formatting.
1. Read our Markdown Style Guide for more information when using Markdown.
1. Do not use ALL CAPS because it feels like shouting. However, there is the all-caps Slack channel for your good-natured shouting needs.
1. We use Unix style (lf) line endings, not Windows style (crlf), please ensure .md text eol=lf is set in the repository's .gitattributes and run git config --global core.autocrlf input on your client.
1. When specifying measurements, please include both Metric and Imperial equivalents.
1. When mentioning currency amounts that team members may need to convert to their local currency (e.g. benefits, expenses, or bonuses), link those amounts to our Exchange Rates section (e.g. 500 USD).
1. Monetary amounts shouldn't have one digit, so prefer \$19.90 to \$19.9.
1. GitLab is an internationally diverse company. US-based team members should not refer to team members outside the US as "international". Instead, use "non-US". Please also avoid the use of "offshore/overseas" to refer to non-American continents.
1. If you have multiple points in a comment or email, please number them. Numbered lists are easier to reference during a discussion over bulleted lists.
1. When you reference an issue, merge request, comment, commit, page, doc, etc. and you have the URL available, please include it.
1. In making URLs, always prefer hyphens to underscores, and always use lowercase.
1. The community includes users, contributors, core team members, customers, people working for GitLab Inc., and friends of GitLab. If you want to refer to "people not working for GitLab Inc.", just say that, and don't use the word "community". If you want to refer to people working for GitLab Inc., you can also use "the GitLab Inc. team", but don't use "GitLab Inc. employees".
1. When we refer to the GitLab community (excluding GitLab team members), please say "wider community" instead of "community".
1. All people working for GitLab (the company) are the GitLab team. We also have the Core team that consists of volunteers.
1. Please always refer to GitLab Inc. people as GitLab team members, not emp